

Syllabus

Course Information

Course Number: VIST 210
Course Title: Time and Interaction
Section: 504 / 505
Time: Tuesday/Thursday 3:55 - 5:35pm
Location: ARCC 206C
Credit Hours: 3 Credits (2 Lecture - 2 Lab)

Instructor Details

Instructor: Michael Bruner
Office: <https://tamu.zoom.us/j/2348119390>
E-Mail: michaelbruner@tamu.edu
Office Hours: Wednesday, 10:00 – 11:30am, or by appointment.

Course Description

Introduction to the history and practice of designing narrative media exploring principles and aesthetics of linear and non-linear/interactive media.

Course Prerequisites

None

Special Course Designation

None

Course Learning Outcomes

Students will learn the language of time-based and interactive storytelling, with a focus on the skills needed to build a strong narrative experience and highly effective visuals for use in linear and non-linear motion graphics, and interactive projects. Students are expected to produce their own creative artifacts that grapple with the techniques and concepts related to time and interaction.

- Demonstrate an understanding of the principles of linear and interactive narratives
- Compare and analyze contemporary linear and interactive narratives
- Analyze the construction of traditional linear narratives (film, animation, comics, short story, graphic novels etc.)
- Analyze interactive narrative aesthetics and construction (video-games, hypertext, websites, interactive video, interactive installation)

- Design and produce motion graphic and interactive narrative projects.

Textbook and/or Resource Materials

There is no required textbook for the course. Readings will be provided.

Optional but recommended: SSD Drive for storing project files. [Example Drive.](#)

Grading Policy

Below is a list of graded activities in the course and their corresponding percentage of the grade.

- **Weekly Assignments (Individual): 15%**
- **Project 1: Linear Narrative (Individual): 30%**
- **Project 2: Interactive Narrative (Individual): 30%**
- **Documentation of Project 1 & 2 (individual): 15%**
- **Attendance: 10%**
- **Total: 100%**

To aid in understanding the method by which your project assignments are evaluated, read the following carefully. The actual grading criteria will be related to these categories but will be more specific in nature.

F: 59 and below: *The student work is unresolved; the intentions are unclear and major criteria or goals lack resolution. Presentation is incomplete and/or of poor quality. There is a complete lack of problem solving, creative content and/or technical merit.*

D: 60 -69: *The solution has problems in two or more major areas; skill and design development is marginal or incomplete. The project lacks imagination and/or design potential.*

C: 70 -79: *The student has solved the problem, but the solution lacks depth of understanding; Some program goals are not completely satisfied and the solution contains little promise even though most issues have been addressed.*

B: 80 -89: *The student work shows imagination and potential. Presentation and design content is good; program requirements are fulfilled but in need of more refinement or development. There are no major issues that would require a total redesign of the project.*

A: 90- 100: *The student work has imagination and the solutions to the problems show understanding and thought. The problem solution is highly developed and well presented; the entire assignment shows depth and breadth and is well coordinated. The assignment's potential has been achieved.*

***Graded Attendance** – Attendance will be taken at the beginning of each class through filling out a QR code. Students that are more than ten minutes late will not receive credit for attendance that day.*

Weekly assignments

Students will have various weekly assignments that need to be done individually or in a group. These are graded separately from project 1 and project 2. These will include:

- *Technique exercises*
- *Conceptual/technical research*
- *In-class presentations*
- *Written analysis of readings and other materials*

Technique exercises

Students will engage with exercises to practice specific techniques in motion graphics and interactive narratives.

Conceptual/technical research

Students will research to develop project concepts and overcome technical challenges. The research could include searching prior works, related articles, online videos, and other supportive materials.

In-class presentations

Students will present project work “in-progress” and “completed” during class.

Written analysis

Students will be asked to choose a relevant work of culture (animation, motion graphic, cinematic sequence, interactive experience, etc.) and analyze it critically with respect to its narrative and formal elements (story, characters, aesthetics, form, technique, etc.)

Project 1: Linear Narrative (individual project)

Students will create non-interactive time-based motion graphic projects that present harmonious movements of graphical elements with sound. Students will use text/shape/image animation techniques to create a linear narrative that viewers can enjoy. The final sequence should not be longer than one minute.

Project 2: Interactive Narrative (individual project)

Students will create an interactive narrative project in which a user can experience an emerging narrative based on their choices and selections throughout the experience.

Design Documents

Students will create design documents for two projects: linear narrative and interactive narrative. The design documents should include concept, concept sketch, interaction, mood board, storyboard, progress, design details, evaluation, and reflection.

Late Work Policy

- *Weekly assignments will not be accepted late. Failure to show your work in class on the due date will result in a zero. Projects, documentation, and research can be submitted late, but with a penalty of 5 points per day, up to 10 days. Later than that will result in a zero.*
- *Work submitted by a student as makeup work for an excused absence is not considered late work and is exempted from the late work policy. (See Student Rule 7.)*
- *Students will be excused from attending class on the day of a graded activity or when attendance contributes to a student's grade, for the reasons stated in Student Rule 7, or other reason deemed appropriate by the instructor.*
- *Please refer to Student Rule 7 in its entirety for information about makeup work, including definitions, and related documentation and timelines.*
- *Absences related to Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 may necessitate a period of more than 30 days for make-up work, and the timeframe for make-up work should be agreed upon by the student and instructor" (Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.1).*
- *"The instructor is under no obligation to provide an opportunity for the student to make up work missed because of an unexcused absence" (Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.2).*
- *Students who request an excused absence are expected to uphold the Aggie Honor Code and Student Conduct Code. (See Student Rule 24.)*

Work submitted by a student as makeup work for an excused absence is not considered late work and is exempted from the late work policy ([Student Rule 7](#)).

Course Schedule

Date	Lecture	Lab	Assignment
Week 1 Aug. 25-29	Introductions	Unreal I Editor Navigation	
Week 2 Sep. 1-5	Time and Story	Building a Primitive Scene	Create a scene in Unreal
Week 3 Sep 8-12	Elements of Linear 2D/3D motion gfx	Unreal II Bouncing Ball, Motion Design, Sequencer	Create a simple animated sequence
Week 4 Sep. 15-19	Materials and Textures	Unreal III Making Materials	Create a PBR material with parameters
Week 5 Sep. 22-26	Cinematography	Unreal V Lighting & Camera Post-processing	Rendering Projects
Week 6 Sep. 29- Oct. 3	Locomotion	Character Controller and State Machine	
Week 7	Project 1 Crit	Project 2 Introductions	Project 1 Due

Oct. 6-10			
Week 8 Oct. 13-17	FALL BREAK	No TUESDAY Class	Locomotion Assignment
Week 9 Oct. 20-24	Presentations Project 2 proposals	Presentations Project 2 proposals	Due: Project 2 proposals Story/Mood boards etc.
Week 10 Oct. 27-31	Interactivity I Widgets & UI	Unreal VI Interfaces	Build a UI with functional buttons
Week 11 Nov. 3-7	Interactivity & Narrative II	Unreal VII Tracking player state and Variables	Implement a branching choice system.
Week 12 Nov. 10-14	Interactivity & Narrative III	Unreal VIII Branching Choices and Decisions	Implement alternative endings and Consequences
Week 13 Nov. 17-21	Interactivity & Narrative IV	Unreal VIII Packaging Projects	Due: Project 2 Prototypes
Week 14 Nov. 24-28	Worktime on Tuesday	THANKSGIVING NO CLASS THURSDAY	
Week 15 Dec. 1-5	Project 2 Crit	Project 2 Crit	Project 2 Due
Week 16	Wrap Up / No Class	Dec. 8 - LAST DAY OF CLASS	

Optional Course Information Items

Canvas (LMS): Information on Canvas is for the sole use of Texas A&M University students enrolled in the class. This online repository contains materials (images, articles, etc.) copyrighted by others that have been included for the purpose of instruction only, under the "fair use" provision of the U.S. copyright laws. Copying these materials to any other site or use of these materials for any other purpose is prohibited. Please log in at <https://canvas.tamu.edu/>

***Technology Support** – if you encounter technical difficulties, please contact ITS/Helpdesk for any technical support with your LMS, computer, and software. Contact the Help Desk directly at 979-845-8300. Pipeline technical support e.g. (UV layout is not correct, importing assets in Unreal, etc.) you should contact the instructor and/or the TA by email or on Zoom chat.*

Learning Resources – Please seek additional learning resources such as the TAMU University Writing Center or related LinkedIn Learning modules appropriate for the course topics.

LinkedIn Learning: Sign in by using your TAMU email
https://www.linkedin.com/learning?trk=homepage-learning_nav-header-logo

The Study Hub website also lists many on-campus learning resources to support you in achieving academic excellence.

University Policies

Attendance Policy

The university views class attendance and participation as an individual student responsibility. Students are expected to attend class and to complete all assignments.

Please refer to [Student Rule 7](#) in its entirety for information about excused absences, including definitions, and related documentation and timelines.

Makeup Work Policy

Students will be excused from attending class on the day of a graded activity or when attendance contributes to a student's grade, for the reasons stated in Student Rule 7, or other reason deemed appropriate by the instructor.

Please refer to [Student Rule 7](#) in its entirety for information about makeup work, including definitions, and related documentation and timelines.

Absences related to Title IX of the Education Amendments of 1972 may necessitate a period of more than 30 days for make-up work, and the timeframe for make-up work should be agreed upon by the student and instructor" ([Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.1](#)).

"The instructor is under no obligation to provide an opportunity for the student to make up work missed because of an unexcused absence" ([Student Rule 7, Section 7.4.2](#)).

Students who request an excused absence are expected to uphold the Aggie Honor Code and Student Conduct Code. (See [Student Rule 24](#).)

Academic Integrity Statement and Policy

"An Aggie does not lie, cheat or steal, or tolerate those who do."

“Texas A&M University students are responsible for authenticating all work submitted to an instructor. If asked, students must be able to produce proof that the item submitted is indeed the work of that student. Students must keep appropriate records at all times. The inability to authenticate one’s work, should the instructor request it, may be sufficient grounds to initiate an academic misconduct case” ([Section 20.1.2.3, Student Rule 20](#)).

Texas A&M at College Station

You can learn more about the Aggie Honor System Office Rules and Procedures, academic integrity, and your rights and responsibilities at aggiehonor.tamu.edu.

Notice of Nondiscrimination

Texas A&M University is committed to providing safe and non-discriminatory learning, living, and work environments for all members of the University community. The University provides equal opportunity to all employees, students, applicants for employment or admission, and the public regardless of race, color, sex (including pregnancy and related conditions), religion, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, or veteran status. Texas A&M University will promptly, thoroughly, and fairly investigate and resolve all complaints of discrimination, harassment (including sexual harassment), complicity and related retaliation based on a protected class in accordance with System Regulation 08.01.01, University Rule 08.01.01.M1, Standard Administrative Procedure (SAP) 08.01.01.M1.01, and applicable federal and state laws. In accordance with Title IX and its implementing regulations, Texas A&M does not discriminate on the basis of sex in any educational program or activity, including admissions and employment. The following person has been designated to handle inquiries and complaints regarding the non-discrimination policies: Jennifer M. Smith, TAMU Associate VP & Title IX Coordinator at YMCA Ste 108, College Station, TX 77843, 979-458-8407, or email civilrights@tamu.edu. For other reporting options, visit <https://ocrcas.ed.gov/contact-ocr> to locate the address and phone number of the office that serves your area, or call 1-800-421-3481.

Civil Rights, Free Speech, and Title IX Policies

Texas A&M University is committed to fostering a learning environment that is safe and productive for all. University policies and federal and state laws prohibit discrimination and harassment based on an individual’s race, color, sex, (including pregnancy and related conditions), religion, national origin, age, disability, genetic information, veteran status, or any other legally protected characteristic. This includes forms of sex-based violence, such as sexual assault, sexual harassment, sexual exploitation, dating/domestic violence, and stalking.

Students can report discrimination/harassment, access supportive resources, or learn more about their options for resolving complaints on the [University’s Civil Rights & Title IX webpage](#).

Students should be aware that all university employees (except medical or mental health providers) are mandatory reporters, which means that if they observe, experience or become aware of an incident that they reasonably believe to be discrimination/harassment alleged to have been committed by or against a person who was a student or employee at the time of the incident, the employee must report the incident to the university.

Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) Policy

Texas A&M University is committed to providing equitable access to learning opportunities for all students. If you experience barriers to your education due to a disability or think you may have a disability, please contact the Disability Resources office on your campus (resources listed below). Disabilities may include, but are not limited to attentional, learning, mental health, sensory, physical, or chronic health conditions. All students are encouraged to discuss their disability related needs with Disability Resources and their instructors as soon as possible.

To request academic accommodations, contact the designated ADA office based on your location:

- Texas A&M University, College of Nursing, College of Dentistry, Irma Lerma Rangel College of Pharmacy College Station, College of Medicine, School of Public Health, Institute of Biosciences and Technology, EnMed Program, Bush School in Washington DC, Mays Business School – CityCentre, TAMU Engineering Academies, Texas A&M University Higher Education Center at McAllen and Texas A&M University at Galveston should contact [Disability Resources](mailto:DisabilityResources@tamu.edu) at (979) 845-1637 or disability@tamu.edu.
- Texas A&M University School of Law should contact the Office of Student Affairs at (817) 212-4111 or law-disability@law.tamu.edu to request accommodations.
- Irma Lerma Rangel College of Pharmacy in Kingsville should contact the Disability Resource Center at Texas A&M University - Kingsville at (361) 593-3024 or drc.center@tamuk.edu to request accommodations.
- Texas A&M University College of Veterinary Medicine & Biomedical Sciences in Canyon should contact the Office of Student Accessibility at West Texas A&M University – Canyon at (806) 651-2335 or osa@wtamu.edu.
- Texas A&M University at Qatar (TAMUQ) should contact the campus psychologist, Dr. Steve Wilson +974-4423-0047 or stephen.wilson@qatar.tamu.edu.

If you are experiencing difficulties with your approved accommodations, contact the office responsible for approving your accommodations or the Texas A&M ADA Coordinator Julie Kuder at ADA.Coordinator@tamu.edu or (979) 458-8407.

Pregnancy Accommodations

Texas A&M provides reasonable accommodations to students due to pregnancy and/or related conditions, such as childbirth, recovery and lactation. Students should contact the University's [Pregnancy Coordinator](mailto:TIX.Pregnancy@tamu.edu) as soon as they become aware of the need for accommodation. Depending on the circumstances, accommodations could include extended time to complete assignments or exams, changes in course sequence, or modifications to the physical classroom environment. Texas A&M will also allow a voluntary leave of absence, ensure the availability of lactation space, and maintain grievance procedures to provide for the prompt and equitable resolution of complaints of sex discrimination. For information regarding pregnancy accommodations, email TIX.Pregnancy@tamu.edu.

Statement on Mental Health and Wellness

Texas A&M University recognizes that mental health and wellness are critical factors influencing a student's academic success and overall wellbeing. Students are encouraged to engage in healthy self-care practices by utilizing the resources and services available through [University Health Services](#) on its [mental health webpage](#). The [TELUS Health Student Support app](#) provides access to professional

counseling in multiple languages anytime, anywhere by phone or chat, and the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline offers 24-hour emergency support at 988 or 988lifeline.org.

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Students needing a listening ear can contact University Health Services (979.458.4584) 24-hour emergency help is also available through the 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline (988) or at 988lifeline.org.

Statement on the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act (FERPA)

FERPA is a federal law designed to protect the privacy of educational records by limiting access to these records, to establish the right of students to inspect and review their educational records and to provide guidelines for the correction of inaccurate and misleading data through informal and formal hearings. Currently enrolled students wishing to withhold any or all directory information items may do so by going to howdy.tamu.edu and clicking on the "Directory Hold Information" link in the Student Records channel on the MyRecord tab. The complete [FERPA Notice to Students](#) and the student records policy is available on the Office of the Registrar webpage.

Items that can never be identified as public information are a student's social security number, citizenship, gender, grades, GPR or class schedule. All efforts will be made in this class to protect your privacy and to ensure confidential treatment of information associated with or generated by your participation in the class.

Directory items include name, UIN, local address, permanent address, email address, local telephone number, permanent telephone number, dates of attendance, program of study (college, major, campus), classification, previous institutions attended, degrees honors and awards received, participation in officially recognized activities and sports, medical residence location and medical residence specialization.

College and Department Policies

Please respect your facilities: studio space, photo lab, shop, labs, etc.

The use of spray paint, spray adhesive or other surface-altering materials is not permitted in the Langford Complex, except in designated zones (we do have spray booth facilities located on our complex). Students who violate this rule will be liable for the expenses associated with repairing damaged building finishes and surfaces.

Throughout the semester and at the end of the semester, your area must be clean of all trash. You are responsible for cleaning your studio, desk, and locker at the end of each semester.

No power tools may be used in the design studio. No dust or odor-producing processes may be conducted in the studio. No wet casting processes may be conducted in the studio. The college shop and spray booth facilities must be used for the above-mentioned processes. Professional behavior and conduct are expected of each student.

All studio desks must be covered. In addition, students must have at minimum an 18" x 24" cutting mat at their desk.

Studio Policy (Required of all Studios)

All students, faculty, administration, and staff of the School of Performance, Visualization & Fine Arts at Texas A&M University are dedicated to the principle that the Design Studio is the central component of an effective education. They are equally dedicated to the belief that students and faculty must lead balanced lives and use time wisely, including time outside the design studio, to gain from all aspects of a university education and world experiences. They also believe that design is the integration of many parts, that process is as important as product, and that the act of design and of professional practice is inherently interdisciplinary, requiring active and respectful collaboration with others.

Students and faculty in every design studio will embody the fundamental values of optimism, respect, sharing, engagement, and innovation. Every design studio will therefore encourage the rigorous exploration of ideas, diverse viewpoints, and the integration of all aspects of visualization (practical, theoretical, scientific, spiritual, and artistic), by providing a safe and supportive environment for thoughtful innovation. Every design studio will increase skills in professional communication, through drawing, modeling, writing, and speaking.

Optional Syllabus Statements

Free Speech and Civil Discourse

Texas A&M recognizes that the pursuit of truth through open and robust discourse is critical to academic inquiry. However, as a community of scholars, the university has an aspirational expectation that such discourse will be conducted in accordance with Aggie Core Values. In this “marketplace of ideas,” we encourage civil dialogue creating an environment that allows individuals to express their ideas and to have their ideas challenged in respectful and responsible ways. Students can learn more about Freedom of Expression and Free Speech on the University’s [website](#) about the [First Amendment](#).

Artificial Intelligence Statements

There may be situations and contexts within this course where you will be asked to use A.I. tools to explore how they can be used. Outside of those circumstances, A.I. tools are not allowed to generate content (text, video, audio, images) that will end up in any work (assignments, activities, responses, etc) that is part of your evaluation in this course. Any student work submitted using A.I. tools should clearly indicate what work is the student’s work and what part is generated by the A.I..

When A.I. is being used for class projects and/or assignments, students **MUST** cite which A.I. application they used, and describe how it was used in their assignment. In such cases, no more than 25% of the student work should be generated by A.I. If any part of this is confusing or uncertain, please reach out to your instructor for a conversation before submitting your work.